# The Case of Rafał Wróbel's Professorship: ZUT/RDN Documents, Legal Services Funding, and an Investigation That Has Been Opened

## Non-identical versions of letters, the aim of "definitively removing from legal circulation" a habilitation resolution, and questions before service of the RDN decision

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> **Translation and source note.** This is a reading translation of the dated Polish publication, not a report of developments after 8 May 2026. It translates the selectable narrative text and all 16 figure captions. Reproductions of official documents, screenshots, and other image content remain in the Polish source PDF; the captions below identify their original PDF pages. Those images have not been recreated or represented as English originals. Repeated running headers and page numbers are not repeated. One file reference is clipped at the right-hand edge of page 1 of the source; it is marked below rather than reconstructed. The Polish PDF remains the source publication.

**The text does not prejudge any person's guilt.**

## Thesis

Before serving its decision in the case of Dr hab. inż. Rafał J. Wróbel, the Council of Scientific Excellence (Rada Doskonałości Naukowej, RDN) should clarify the status of the documents circulating between ZUT and RDN: the issuer's version, the versions received, the document bearing ZUT stamps, the metadata, the scope of the attachments, the funding of legal services, and the need to preserve data storage media at ZUT. The text describes documented concerns and questions requiring clarification.

The Council of Scientific Excellence is to serve its decision in the case of Dr hab. inż. Rafał J. Wróbel. Before doing so, it should answer one fundamental question: which documents did the bodies work from, and are these the same versions that are circulating between ZUT and RDN today?

**Figure 1.** PUESC report: the result "INVALID/INCORRECT" for the file attributed to the RDN letter of 18 October 2023. *Facsimile: Polish source PDF, p. 1.*

Since December 2025, RDN had been informed about problems with the integrity of the file attributed to the RDN letter of 18 October 2023, the document bearing ZUT stamps, the metadata, the differing scope of attachments, and the funding of external legal services. A prosecution document dated 22 April 2026 also states that an investigation was opened into abuse of authority in connection with actions concerning Rafał Wróbel's habilitation proceedings.

This text does not prejudge any person's guilt. It presents questions that should be clarified before a decision: what is the source version of the documents, where did the stamped version come from, which transmission channels were used, which attachments were provided to the respective entities, and whether the IT data needed to reconstruct the circulation of the documents have been preserved.

## 1. RDN received a notification as early as December 2025

As early as 19 December 2025, a letter was sent to RDN concerning its letter of 18 October 2023, file reference DRKN.Z2.401.17.2**… [translator's note: the reference is clipped at the right-hand edge of page 1 of the Polish PDF]**. It stated that the PDF file circulating publicly did not show the integrity of the qualified electronic signature when verified through PUESC. The message included the PUESC report, a scan of the one-page document bearing ZUT stamps, an analysis of the metadata of files associated with Marek Wroński, and material described as confirmation that the information had been delivered to the editorial office of *Forum Akademickie*.

The PUESC report gave the result "INVALID/INCORRECT" and the detail: "the object to which the signature refers has been altered." The letter to RDN described this as a file-integrity problem, not as a definitive legal characterisation.

**Figure 2.** Letter to RDN of 19 December 2025: the notification concerning file integrity, the document bearing ZUT stamps, the metadata, and the attachments provided. *Facsimile: Polish source PDF, p. 2.*

**Figure 3.** Headers of the message to RDN of 19 December 2025: recipients, Message-ID, and the list of attachments sent with the notification concerning the integrity of the file DRKN.Z2.401.17.2023. *Facsimile: Polish source PDF, p. 3.*

## 2. Reminder: the issuer's version, checksum, and transmission channel

On 2 January 2026, the requester reminded RDN of the request and again asked for the source version of the letter issued by RDN, its checksum, and information about the transmission channel and date. An important distinction was made: ZUT may hold a version received in the course of circulation, whereas only RDN can unambiguously confirm the issuer's version and the transmission details.

**Figure 4.** Reminder to RDN of 2 January 2026: request for the source version, checksum, and transmission details. *Facsimile: Polish source PDF, p. 4.*

## 3. RDN replied, referring to a qualified electronic signature and EZD

On 26 January 2026, RDN replied that all letters sent to the relevant institutions had carried an appropriate qualified electronic signature, and that the letters in the electronic document management system (EZD) were properly secured. This means that RDN received the notification concerning the integrity problem and document versions, and then gave a response addressing the signature and the security of the letters in EZD.

**Figure 5.** RDN's reply of 26 January 2026: information about the qualified electronic signature and the security of letters in EZD. *Facsimile: Polish source PDF, p. 4.*

## 4. The document bearing ZUT stamps and the version problem

A one-page document entitled “Letter concerning the initiation of proceedings for a declaration of invalidity” is in circulation. It bears the stamps of ZUT’s Main Registry and Rector’s Office, but lacks the file reference `DRKN.Z2.401.17.2023` in its heading and does not correctly identify the signature on the document itself. The problem is not merely the quality of the scan. It concerns the document’s status: was it RDN’s issuer version, a received copy, a printout, a scan, a processed document, or some other reproduction?

An additional problem concerns language and formal presentation: the document attributed to the RDN letter contains unusual editorial and formal features. The question for RDN is therefore not only “does the signature validate?” but also: did this particular document originate in RDN’s system as the issuer’s version, and does RDN accept its use as its own letter or application in this case?

## 5. Comparisons: it is not just about scans

A separate precautionary letter was sent to the Rector of ZUT requesting the preservation of originals, metadata, logs, and draft versions. It pointed out that the differences were not limited to scan quality, but concerned the presence or absence of stamps, annotations, margins, cropping, the positioning of content, page layout, and the scope of attachments.

**Figure 6.** Comparison of documents: RDN’s initiation of proceedings and the Niemirko contract — examples of non-identical versions or reproductions. *Facsimile: Polish source PDF, p. 5.*

The comparisons do not, in themselves, determine the legal characterisation. They do, however, show that the documentation exists as differing images, renderings, or reproductions, which requires the document’s circulation route, source versions, and versions submitted for acceptance to be established.

**Figure 7.** Comparisons: the contract’s signature page and ZUT’s responses to two requesters — differing scopes of attachments. *Facsimile: Polish source PDF, p. 6.*

Comparing the scope of the attachments shows that one response refers to the contract and an annex, whereas the other lists a broader set including the contract, annex, power of attorney, bills, and statements of hours worked. This requires clarification of whether different requesters were given different scopes of material and on what basis.

## 6. From teaching to the “definitive removal” of a habilitation?

A separate problem concerns the documentation of legal services for the proceedings for a declaration of invalidity. The documents identify an objective encompassing actions leading to the “definitive removal from legal circulation” of the habilitation resolution. The funding source was identified as “other revenue from the teaching activities of WTiICh, 504/11000-1-12.” The reply from the Rector of ZUT dated 3 February 2026 also stated that the contract for services (*umowa zlecenia*) and the bills formed the basis for paying the remuneration, and that the Rector’s signature, together with the countersignatures of the Bursar and the person responsible for the funds — the Dean of WTiICh — signified acceptance and consent to incur the expenditure.

**Figure 8.** Contract for services and funding documentation: the objective encompassing the "definitive removal" of the resolution and the source of WTiICh funds. *Facsimile: Polish source PDF, p. 7.*

This raises a question of public interest: why were a unit's funds associated with teaching activities used to fund external legal services for proceedings aimed at removing a particular researcher's habilitation resolution from legal circulation? The question does not prejudge any person's guilt. It does, however, require clarification of the funding source, the basis for commissioning the work, the scope of the service, the approval of the expenditure, and the role of those responsible for the WTiICh faculty route.

## 7. Metadata and file sources: why data preservation is necessary

A separate strand concerns document metadata and materials associated with Marek Wroński. The packages submitted to the prosecution authorities pointed to the need to preserve file sources, metadata, logs, and document versions, and to the possible need for an assessment by an expert in digital forensics and electronic signatures.

Marek Wroński's letter of 15 October 2023 is significant not because it establishes responsibility in itself, but because it provides a reference point for analysing the environment in which later files were created. The PUESC report of 8 May 2026 for this file identifies a PAdES/BES signature, the signing date of 15 October 2023 at 20:38:02, and the signatory: MAREK WROŃSKI. The current verification result is negative because the certificate's validity period has been exceeded, not because the document's content was found to have been altered.

**Figure 9.** Marek Wroński's letter of 15 October 2023, pages 1–2: a document marked as electronically signed, providing a reference point for metadata analysis. *Facsimile: Polish source PDF, p. 8.*

**Figure 10.** PUESC report for Wroński's letter of 15 October 2023: PAdES/BES signature, signatory MAREK WROŃSKI, and the negative result of current validation associated with the certificate's validity period having been exceeded. *Facsimile: Polish source PDF, p. 9.*

This strand does not determine any person's responsibility. It does, however, reinforce the main thesis of this text: comparing printouts and scans is not enough in this case. If the dispute concerns document versions, their provenance, their circulation route, the authorship of files, metadata, and how attachments were disclosed, it is necessary to preserve the source material: editable files, PDF exports, mail logs, registry records, EZD systems, storage media, and working copies.

**Figure 11.** Metadata analysis — technical summary: the qualification that a final attribution of actions requires a full expert opinion and access to the original storage media. *Facsimile: Polish source PDF, p. 10.*

## 8. The decision of the commission attached to the Minister: the earlier disciplinary penalty was not upheld

Wróbel's case also has a disciplinary dimension. By its decision of 15 September 2025, the Disciplinary Commission attached to the Minister of Science and Higher Education set aside the decision of ZUT's commission and remitted the case for reconsideration. This is not a formal acquittal, but the appellate body's reasoning is significant for Wróbel: it identifies procedural and factual errors, and errors in characterisation, in ZUT's earlier decision.

**Figure 12.** Decision of the Disciplinary Commission attached to the Minister of 15 September 2025, pages 1–2: setting aside the decision of ZUT's commission, remitting the case for reconsideration, and the beginning of the reasoning. *Facsimile: Polish source PDF, p. 11.*

The reasoning stated, among other things, that correspondence sent within an organisational structure to a specified group of recipients is not public in nature; that announcing an intention to use lawful supervisory or inspection procedures does not constitute an unlawful threat; and that terms such as "unnecessary correspondence," "unjustified criticism," or "exerting pressure" cannot replace specific findings of fact.

**Figure 13.** Minutes of ZUT's disciplinary commission of 10 April 2026: presentation of the decision of the commission attached to the Minister and appointment of a new panel. *Facsimile: Polish source PDF, p. 12.*

The minutes of the meeting of ZUT's disciplinary commission of 10 April 2026 show that, following the decision of the commission attached to the Minister, ZUT was again organising the adjudicating panel. The minutes also recorded that some people did not wish to participate in the current proceedings because they worked at WTiICh or had been members of the earlier panel.

## 9. The prosecution: from the submission of material to an opened investigation

The case now has more than public, administrative, and disciplinary dimensions. A document from the Kraków-Śródmieście Zachód District Prosecutor's Office in Kraków dated 22 April 2026, file reference `4138-1.Ds.145.2026`, states that, by a prosecutor's decision of the same date, an investigation was opened into abuse of authority between 20 October 2023 and 6 November 2023 in Szczecin.

The notice states that the investigation concerns actions connected with disciplinary proceedings and administrative proceedings for the invalidation of Dr hab. Rafał Wróbel's habilitation procedure; the conclusion of a contract for legal services with a legal adviser's practice for the purpose of checking the credibility of the habilitation procedure; and actions taken in supervising the proceedings for a declaration of invalidity of the habilitation proceedings. The document cites Article 231 § 1 of the Polish Criminal Code and action to the detriment of the public interest and Rafał Wróbel's private interest.

**Figure 14.** Notice from the Kraków-Śródmieście Zachód District Prosecutor's Office in Kraków of 22 April 2026 concerning the opening of an investigation, file reference `4138-1.Ds.145.2026`. *Facsimile: Polish source PDF, p. 13.*

The opening of an investigation does not, in itself, determine the responsibility of any particular person. It does mean, however, that the case is no longer solely a dispute about the interpretation of documents, university communication, or standards of administrative procedure. It is a formal criminal proceeding in which the source versions of documents, metadata, system logs, storage media, correspondence, document-circulation records, and the way legal services were funded may be significant.

The preservation of IT data remains particularly important. One of the earlier prosecution letters indicated the need to preserve IT storage media at ZUT in Szczecin without delay. If the authorities' interest concerns document versions, their provenance, their circulation route, and who had access to them and when, simply comparing printouts and scans will not be enough. The sources need to be preserved: registry systems, mailboxes, source files, logs, storage media, and metadata.

An earlier letter from the Regional Prosecutor's Office in Szczecin documented the forwarding of the notification submitted by Fundacja Science Watch Polska for further handling by the competent authorities. The later notice from the Kraków-Śródmieście Zachód District Prosecutor's Office, however, confirms the formal opening of an investigation. It is therefore now justified to speak not only of a "prosecution track," but of an investigation that has been opened — while retaining the qualification that the opening of proceedings does not, in itself, determine any person's guilt.

**Figure 15.** Letter from the Regional Prosecutor's Office in Szczecin concerning the forwarding of the notification submitted by Fundacja Science Watch Polska for further handling (excerpt without the "For information" field). *Facsimile: Polish source PDF, p. 14.*

## 10. A pseudonymous correspondence channel: the pseudonym is not the problem

In part of the correspondence, ZUT addressed the sender's status, describing the message as an "anonymous submission." The correspondence was, however, conducted through a consistently used pseudonymous channel, from which requests for public information were submitted concerning specific documents, dates, attachments, and metadata.

There is no need for this text to determine who "Robert Jordan" was in the correspondence or how the pseudonym itself should be interpreted. What matters is that the questions concerned specific documents and their circulation. If, instead of answering questions about document versions, the scope of attachments, message headers, and metadata, an authority shifts attention to the sender's name, it does not resolve the problem. On the contrary: it shows that a question about documents has been replaced by a question about the person asking it.

**Figure 16.** Reply from the official address of the Dean of WTiICh to correspondence conducted through a pseudonymous channel: a message entitled "anonymous submissions" (*anonimy*). *Facsimile: Polish source PDF, p. 15.*

For this text, therefore, the decisive issue is not who is behind the sender's name. The decisive matters are the content of the replies, the scope of the attachments disclosed, the message headers, the dates, the sources of the documents, and the question of why different requesters were shown non-identical scopes of material.

## 11. A question for RDN, ZUT, and the authorities before further decisions

RDN is at a particular moment. On the one hand, it has informed the party that the decision is to be served. On the other hand, even before service of the decision, RDN had been receiving notifications about document integrity, the status of the letter bearing ZUT stamps, file metadata, the funding of legal services, and the need to preserve storage media at ZUT.

Following the opening of the investigation, these questions have become more significant. It is no longer only a matter of good administration or of responding to a request for public information. The question is whether administrative and academic bodies will take their decisions in the knowledge that some of the documents and actions fall within the scope of a criminal proceeding.

The fundamental question is whether RDN will serve its decision without clarifying which documents formed the basis of the earlier actions in Wróbel's case, or whether it will first identify which documents are source versions and which are received copies or secondary reproductions, and whether the members of the competent body were informed of the unresolved documentary concerns.

RDN still has the opportunity to resolve the case in an institutionally sound manner: identify the issuer's version, request metadata and circulation records from ZUT, confirm that the materials were provided to the members of the competent body, and clearly distinguish any document-circulation problems on the part of ZUT or WTiICh from its own actions.

ZUT, in turn, should explain whether and when the source documents, metadata, logs, mailboxes, registry records, storage media, and draft document versions concerning the invalidity proceedings and legal services were preserved. If non-identical reproductions of documents are circulating, the response cannot be limited to saying that "they are just scans." Differences in stamps, annotations, margins, content positioning, the scope of attachments, and the appearance of documents do not, in themselves, determine the legal characterisation, but they create an obligation to preserve the source material.

In this context, ZUT's public standards towards young researchers also become significant. If university office-holders appear publicly as experts on grants, publications, and academic careers, it is reasonable to expect the university, in parallel, to explain the funding of external legal services, the circulation of non-identical document versions, the handling of staff complaints, and the preservation of IT storage media.

This text does not prejudge any person's guilt. It does, however, indicate that, before further proceedings in Wróbel's case, a general assurance that documents are "in the case file," or that letters in electronic systems are secured, is not sufficient. Specific answers are needed: what is the source version, what is the file's hash, where did the stamped version come from, which transmission channels were used, what were the dates of receipt, which attachments were provided to the respective entities, and whether the IT data needed to reconstruct this have been preserved.

## Conclusion

Wróbel's case shows that a document in academic proceedings is not a formality. It is the basis for decisions and for a person's reputation and career. When non-identical versions or reproductions of letters enter circulation, when the funding of legal services requires clarification, when a law-enforcement authority opens an investigation, and an administrative decision is due to be served in parallel, a reasonable standard is simple: first preserve the sources, metadata, and storage media; then take the decision.

The question is therefore not who "Robert Jordan" was in the correspondence. The question is whether institutions can answer questions about their own documents when the answer may be inconvenient for them.

None of us is an island. For whom, then, does the bell toll in this case? For Rafał Wróbel? For the Dean? For the former Rector? For the West Pomeranian University of Technology in Szczecin? For the Council of Scientific Excellence? Or perhaps for the entire academic community, which must decide whether it can honestly correct its own mistakes?

The Ministry still has a chance to hear this bell. Not in order to condemn anyone in advance, but to prevent a similar mechanism from being repeated against other people.

## Version verification

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